

Lesson 2: Writing paragraphs

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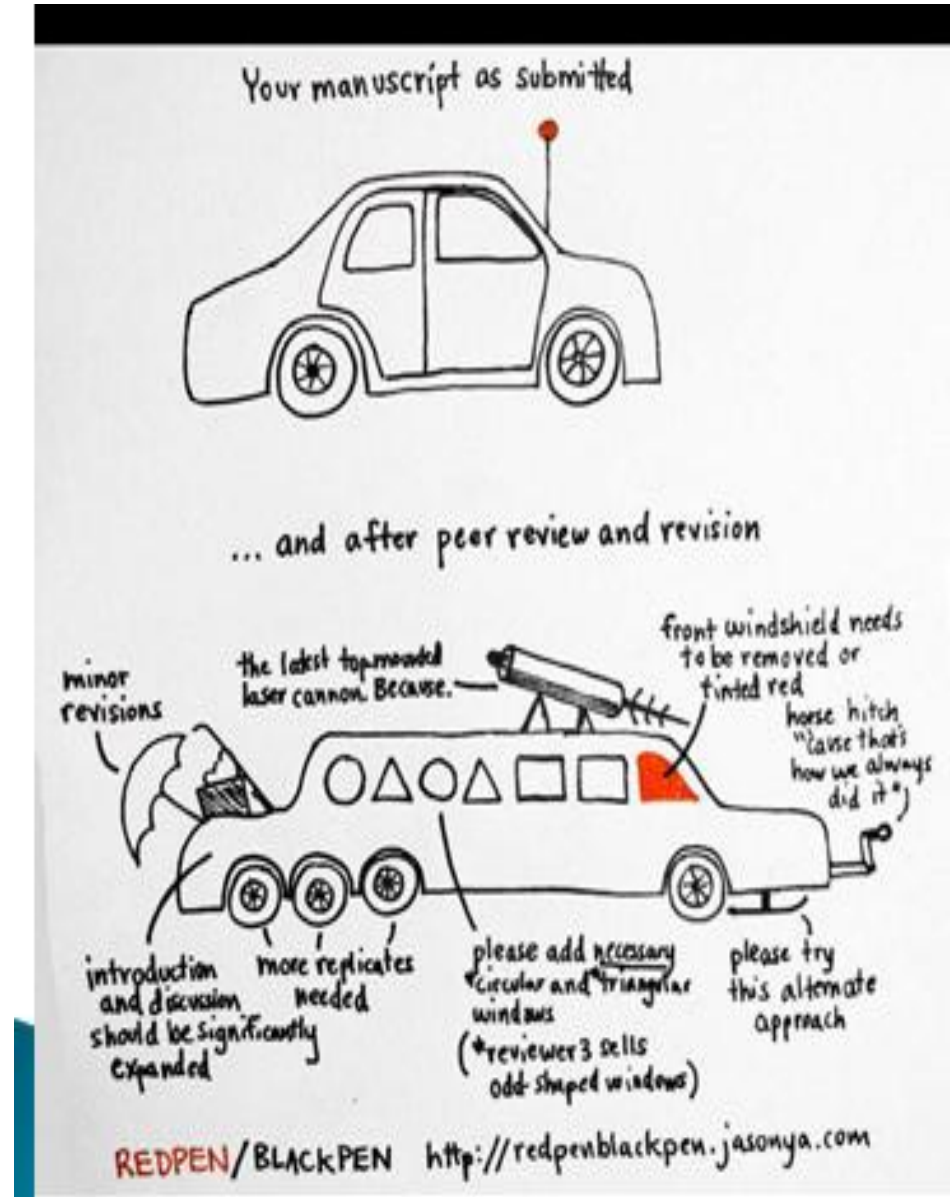
Scientific writing: Swiss TPH

Swiss TPH

Swiss Tropical and Public Health Institute
Schweizerisches Tropen- und Public Health-Institut
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Objectives

Lesson 2

- Differences between English and German (and French) scientific writing
- How to write paragraphs: paragraph structure, logical flow of ideas, using linking words
- How to establish cohesion & coherence
- How to use summarising nouns
- Reviewing and explanation of the peer review process in the course

German vs. English grammar – sentences and paragraphs

GERMAN

- Can sustain very long sentences
 - Rich in cases
 - Informative gendered pronouns
 - Many objects (direct & indirect)
 - Many different way to structure sentences.
- German speakers are patient
 - Verb comes at the end
 - No interruptions
- Sentence is main unit of meaning.
- Paragraphing is not strict.

ENGLISH

- Sentences must be short
 - Crippled cases and no genders
 - One object, or parallel list of like objects
- English speakers are impatient
 - Subject + verb at beginning
 - Converge on meaning
- Paragraphs are main unit of meaning
- Paragraphing is strict.

[Academic Writing and Culture: An Overview of Diff... – Meta – Érudit](#)

Writing paragraphs in English

In English, the paragraph is the main unit of meaning. The rules for good paragraphs are strict.

Paragraph structure

Paragraph: unit of the manuscript

One main idea per paragraph, usually stated in the first sentence (which often is the **topic sentence**)

Cramming in more than one main idea confuses reader

Use paragraphs to signal when you're changing from one idea to another.

Within paragraphs, sentences are connected in a logical way to make texts cohesive and coherent.

Types of paragraphs

Most paragraphs are **single topic**. They have *one subject*, named in the topic sentence, supported by detail sentences with the same subject.

Some paragraphs are **transitional**, and carry you swiftly through a series of subjects, to bring you up to date on a topic.

Topic Sentence: general summary of the idea

Detail

Detail

Detail

Transition to the next paragraph...

English paragraph
structure

- Every *paragraph* describes a single idea, which is usually contained in the first sentence, the topic sentence.
- Subsequent sentences *support* the topic sentence.
- A *transition sentence* often could lead into the next paragraph.

Organisation in a paragraph

A **topic sentence** is followed by several **supporting statements**. In texts with good readability these statements follow a consistent pattern of organisation, one that flows naturally from the topic statement. Some of the **most commonly used patterns of organisation in academic and professional writing** are:

- chronological description,
- cause and effect analysis,
- comparison and contrast,
- listing, and
- general to particular order of details.

Each of these patterns has certain characteristic features.

Example paragraph elaborating on a topic sentence

- The **topic statement** (also referred to as topic sentence) expresses the main idea or topic of a paragraph, and often indicates how this idea will be developed.
- Gasohol: a mixture of petrol and ethanol used as fuel in internal combustion engines
- Fuel cell vehicles work with hydrogen

Unlike gasohol-powered cars, fuel cell vehicles are virtually pollution free. A methanol fuel system in a vehicle works through chemical reactions that leave the air clean. Firstly, a fuel processor breaks the methanol down into carbon dioxide and hydrogen. The hydrogen is then pumped into the cell itself, where it combines with oxygen to form water. This **reaction** causes electrons to be traded between molecules, which produces current that travels through an external circuit. The net products are thus carbon dioxide, water, and electricity. **By contrast**, when **gasohol** is burned in an internal combustion engine, it produces the same nitrous oxides that gasoline does.

- The topic sentence in this paragraph is effective because it tells the reader what the main idea of the paragraph is. It also suggests the way in which the paragraph will develop, namely with a description of the fuel cell process and a comparison of its waste products with those of an internal combustion engine.

Paragraph structure: activity

Open one of the theses or research articles you have selected to use for this course or for your thesis.

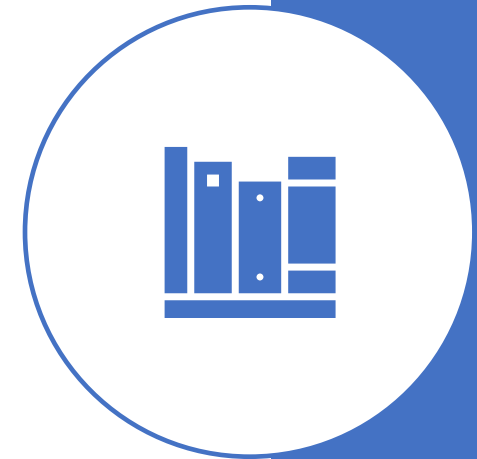
- Select a paragraph in the Introduction or Discussion sections.
- Read the first sentence and then the rest of the paragraph.
- Identify the topic sentence.
- Identify the organisation pattern, for example chronological description, cause and effect analysis, comparison and contrast, listing, and general to particular order of details.



Skimming and scanning texts

Skimming and scanning are two useful reading techniques. They can help you to find information really quickly in a text.

- **Skimming** is when you look over a text quickly to get the general idea of it. A basic way of skimming is to read the first (topic) sentence of each paragraph, because that contains the main idea of that paragraph.
- **Scanning** is when you look over a text quickly, line by line, hunting for key words, dates, names and numbers. It's a useful skill to use when you need answers to specific questions.



How to skim-read texts to get the gist (the general idea/meaning of a text)

Skim-reading texts is an essential skill for students.

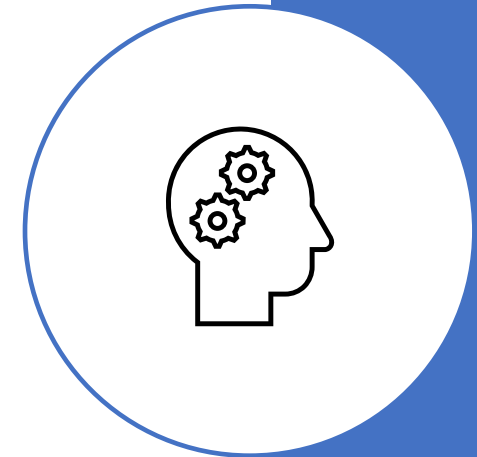
In an English text with good paragraph structure, you can get the gist (central meaning) of the whole text if you skim it in this way:

1. Read the first paragraph and last paragraph of the text in full.
2. Read the first sentences of the paragraphs in between.
3. Read headings, sub-headings, bullet points or key words (those in bold, italics, capitals or underlined) to guide you.

Skim-reading research articles: activity

Open one of the research articles you have selected to use for this course or for your thesis. Skim-read it in the way suggested. How well could you get the gist of the article?

1. Read the first paragraph and last paragraph of the text in full.
2. Read the first sentences of the paragraphs in between.
3. Read headings, sub-headings, bullet points or key words (those in bold, italics, capitals or underlined) to guide you.



COHERENCE AND COHESION

Coherence is the logical unity and organization of ideas in a text.

Lack of coherence means that points within one paragraph are unrelated (or paragraphs within one text are unrelated).

Cohesion is the connection of sentences through linguistic means, which allow to achieve a smooth text flow effect. Cohesive elements include conjunctions, reference words, substitution and lexical devices such as repetition of words, collocations, and lexical groups.

What we need to know is that the text should not sound like a list of bullet points (lack of cohesion), and ideas should be placed in a logical order (coherence).

Cohesion and coherence

A cohesive text FLOWS well. The ideas and sentences are linked. (See examples on slides below.)

To make writing cohesive and coherent, one can repeat key words and synonyms, as well as use *linking words* to guide the reader.

A cohesive text refers to other parts of the text (e.g. 'the above-mentioned aims') using words like *they, this, those, some* and *its* to create a well-organized piece of writing that will make it easier for the reader to follow the complex arguments in academic writing.

Cohesion at paragraph level

See also the previous example paragraph about fuel cell vehicles, in which repetition and linking words are used to achieve cohesion.

Family structure and society

Throughout history, a priority for every known society has been to develop a **reliable arrangement** for the procreation and rearing of children, an **institution** where members also cooperate to give each other emotional and economic support and where children receive **their** socialisation. **This universal institution** is the **family**. **However**, although the **family** performs a range of broadly similar functions in **human societies**, **its** form has varied widely according to the differing values and circumstances of **those societies**. (p. 271)

Paragraph flow and structure: Move from general to specific

- **Topic sentence:** usually the first sentence of the paragraph. It gives the **main idea** and the **topic**. It is the **most general** sentence of the paragraph.
- Each paragraph deals with only ONE main idea.
- The **supporting sentences** come after the topic sentence; they explain the topic sentence and provide more **detail**.
- The **concluding sentence** comes at the end of the paragraph. It can finish a paragraph by giving a **final comment** about the topic or **repeating / connecting to** the main idea. It could also establish a link to the topic of the next paragraph.

Old → New information flow

Clear connections between sentences in a paragraph create coherence:

1. Familiar information > new info 1
 2. Familiar info 1 > new info 2
 3. Familiar info 2 > new info 3
 4. Familiar info 3 > new info 4
- *Careful repetition* of key words and structures
 - In addition, *linking words* to guide the reader

Example of old to new information flow

- Establish internal flow by placing old information first and new information last. For example:

Farmers try to provide optimal growing conditions for crops by using soil additives to adjust soil pH. One way to raise the pH of the soil is an additive made from pulverized chalk called garden lime or agricultural limestone.

- Note how the 'new information', 'soil additives to adjust soil pH', becomes the 'old information' that starts the next sentence: 'One way to raise the pH of the soil'...

Example of good information flow in a paragraph

Technology often drives science. Among the most impressive recent **technological advances** is **DNA sequencing. More efficient sequencing** has reduced the **cost of generating sequence data** significantly. **Cheaper data** in turn enables more researchers to do data-intensive experiments, which results in **a huge amount of data** being released into the public domain. **Dealing with data in such large quantity** will require a **new generation of scientists**.

This subject string clearly is shifting, but it does so in an intended, logical flow that builds up to the final point of the paragraph.

Old becomes new information flow is used. Each subject connects to the previous subject (or is the object of the previous sentence): Technology... DNA sequencing... More efficient sequencing... Cheaper data... Huge amount of data... Dealing with data....

New generation of scientists (which might lead to the next paragraph that could focus on this new generation of scientists)

Writing tips: Link sentences with linking words & phrases (1)

More linking words, examples and explanations can be found in the script.

- *Order/Sequence:*

eventually, finally, first, firstly, in the end, in the first place, in the second place, lastly, later, next, second, secondly, to begin with, thereafter, finally, lastly, at first (not the same as 'first')

- *Reason/justification:*

Because/as/for/since, in order to, so as to, so that, accordingly, as a consequence/consequently, as a result, for this reason, hence, owing to (this), so, therefore, thus

Writing tips: Frequently used linking words & phrases (2)

- *Contrast:*

However, in contrast, still, by comparison, instead, even though/although, in contrast, on the other hand, nevertheless, nonetheless, conversely, albeit (pronounced 'all-bee-it')

- *Conclusion and Summary :*

and so, finally, in brief, in closing, in conclusion, on the whole, to conclude, to summarize

- *Example words:*

as an example, for example, for instance, specifically, thus, to illustrate

Frequently used linking words & phrases (3)

- *Restatement words*: in other words, in short, in simpler terms, that is, *i.e.*, to put it differently, to repeat
- *Insistence words*: in fact, indeed
- *Purpose*: to, in order to, so as to (Note the word order of the negative forms 'in order not to' and 'so as not to')
- *Time words*: when, whenever, while, before, after, until, as soon as, once, by the time, since, in the meantime

‘this’ and ‘it’

Correct use aids coherence

These common, useful pronouns can cause confusion when the antecedent is not clear. Avoid using them on their own.

Example: ‘Free information about cancer treatment. To get **it**, phone 0800...’

To get what? Cancer treatment or information?

Rather use ‘This / Such’ with a **summary noun** in academic writing, eg. ‘Such information can be obtained by calling...’, or in plain English, ‘To get such/this information, phone...’ See examples on next slide.

Use summarizing/summary nouns: examples

- To write clearly, cohesively and coherently in science, **it is better to use the pronouns *this*, *that*, *these* and *those* with a summarizing noun**. When using the pronoun *it*, also make sure that it is clear what *it* refers to, else replace *it* with *this/these* and a summarizing noun. In the student paragraph below, this is one example:

In recent years, the number of students applying to degree programmes has increased steadily, while the number of places has remained constant. *This situation* has resulted in intense competition for admission. (More examples in the script)

Now consider these examples and indicate what the words in *italics* refer to.

- There have been several recent stories of parents overstepping the boundaries to help their children at school. ***This phenomenon***, known as ‘helicopter parenting’, is satirized in a novel “May contain nuts”.
- Cities work best when traffic flows freely. Workers are most productive when they feel fit and well. A city with a strong cycling programme can achieve both of ***these objectives***.

Another example of summary noun use

However, in the 1980s the debt crisis and the ensuing contraction of budgets prompted a re-appraisal of public sector provision. Donors began lobbying for the restructuring of public services; by the 1990s, they were demanding full-scale privatisation. However, implementation of such reforms has been slow.

(The use of the summary noun 'such reforms' summarises the ideas 're-appraisal of public sector' and 'restructuring of public services'.)

Task:

Follow 'This/These' with a summarising noun for clarity: Choose the best summarising nouns

According to a recent survey, 26% of all American adults, down from 38% 30 years ago, now smoke. This _____ can be partly attributed to mounting evidence linking smoking and fatal diseases, such as cancer.

1. decline 2. decrease 3. drop
4. improvement 5. reduction

Such use of this/that + noun leads to good old to new information flow in the text.

See the next slide for a list of some of the most frequently used summarizing nouns in scientific writing.

Some summarizing nouns with this/these

- advance
- advice
- amount
- area
- argument
- change
- claim
- comment
- conclusion
- crisis
- criticism
- description
- development
- difficulty
- disagreement
- discussion
- drop
- estimate
- example
- explanation
- fall
- idea
- increase
- issue
- measure
- method
- misunderstanding
- number
- objective
- phenomenon
- policy
- problem
- proposal
- reduction
- remark
- report
- rise
- situation
- subject
- suggestion
- system
- trend
- view
- warning

Insert suitable summarising nouns

- Normal average human skin temperature is 37°C. At any lower environmental temperature, heat will be lost from the skin to the environment as the body attempts to heat up the air in direct contact with the body. **This** _____ is known as conduction.
- Haigney concludes that driving performance decreases greatly when drivers use their mobile phones. **This** _____ is consistent with recent reviews of the literature on driving distractions.



Writing cohesively and coherently using various forms of repetition (examples on next slide)

The techniques, reference words and phrases used for repetition are as follows:

1. simple repetition (i.e. the exact repetition of a word)
2. repetition with grammatical transformation (e.g. noun to verb)
3. demonstrative pronouns (especially 'this' and 'these')
4. personal pronouns (especially 'it' and 'they')
5. relative pronouns (which, that)
6. determiners (especially 'such', 'this', or 'these') followed by a previously used noun, called a summarizing / summary noun
7. synonyms

Writing cohesively and coherently using various forms of repetition: examples

1. The assembly machine uses robotic arms. The *arms* (simple repetition) can be telescopic or of a fixed length.
2. A good paragraph is designed to be easily readable. *Readability* (repetition with grammatical transformation) has several aspects.
3. The assembly machine uses robotic arms. *These* (demonstrative pronoun) can be telescopic or of a fixed length.
4. First of all, the samples were weighed. *They* (personal pronoun for 'samples') were then placed in an acid bath.
5. A solution was required *that* (relative pronoun) fulfilled all the above requirements.
6. After extraction, metals often undergo several further production processes. *These processes* (determiner plus repeated noun = **summarizing noun**) result in materials with significantly superior characteristics.
7. The project group had to deal with various problems. However, the *difficulties* (synonym for 'problems' = **summarizing noun**) were overcome and the project was completed on time.

Sample text showing cohesive devices

Structures which are most at risk from progressive failure are **those** that are highly optimized and operate at a high proportion of their maximum load. Aerospace frames are perhaps the most obvious example of **such structures** and it is in the design of **these frames** that much attention has been paid to ensuring **fail**-safety. *Since* **they** must have as low a weight as possible, **aerospace frames** are **optimized** to ensure that no part is larger than necessary. *However*, **this** means that a variation from the assumed **load** pattern, which would occur in the case of local damage, could have a serious effect on members close to the site of **damage**. *Therefore*, allowance must be made for **this possibility**. **Fail-safe** or damage-tolerant design is **that** which preserves the serviceability of **members**, *even after* **they** have been **damaged**. The main method by which **this** is achieved is the incorporation of alternative **load** paths into **the structure**. **These alternative paths** produce multiple redundancy; *thus*, when **damage** occurs, there are several other **members** that can carry the extra **load**.

Creating overall text (full-text) cohesion and coherence

Introductory sentences in sections/ chapters

Linking sentences between sections

Use of linking devices such as conjunctions and careful repetition of key words

Linking sections: **link the Introduction and Conclusions sections** (to show if you closed the 'gap' or solved the problem)

Link the Methods to the Results (what did you find at each step)

3 TECHNIQUES TO AVOID PLAGIARISM

While conducting your research, you might find that others have developed similar ideas.

There could be another researcher who may have



Devised an investigative technique



Described the natural history of a disease



Discovered the structure of a compound



Described an unchanging process



This technique by Smith et. al. has been described perfectly. I can't possibly explain it better than them. Can I reuse this work as it is?

Absolutely NOT! This is extremely unethical!

If you use the existing ideas, words, or work of another person, without giving them due credit, you are plagiarizing their work.

So what if I want to use part of another researcher's work? Is there an ethical way to do this?



YES! And there's more than one way to avoid plagiarism!

Here are 3 things you could do:

Quote

Use the exact same words as the original

The quoted sentence must be enclosed within double quotes ("...") or set apart from the rest of the text as a block quotation

Paraphrase

Rewrite the original ideas in your own words

The paraphrased sentence must only match the source document in terms of meaning, not exact words

Summarize

Put the original ideas into your own words

The summarized text must provide a short overview of the source text and be much shorter than the original version

1. Quote
2. Paraphrase
3. Summarize and paraphrase

Always include the references!

How to imitate good writers without plagiarising

To copy **content** = plagiarism

- WHAT we say
- Content and language
- Imitation is strictly prohibited!

Do copy **phrases**

- ✓ The WAY we say things
- ✓ Language “tool”
- ✓ Imitation is allowed (and encouraged!)

- **Paraphrase**
- If in doubt, check the **Harvard Guide to Using Sources**
- Collect useful expressions in a **phrase bank** such as that of the [University of Manchester](#) that suggests useful phrases for all sections of articles.

Using the plagiarism check tool, Turnitin

- Go to the special **ADAM Workspace Plagiarism check under the Assignments tab**. Click on the following link https://adam.unibas.ch/goto_adam_fold_1951092.html to access the Workspace: Upload your assignments here to check for plagiarism.
- First, click the 'Start/Launch' button.
- A new browser window will open.
- Here you upload the first draft of your assignment without any comments (before peer review).
- Make sure your name and the assignment details are on the document, for example '1John Smith'.
- Click to agree to submit the text to Turnitin.
- It takes some time for Turnitin to generate the similarity report, up to 24 hours!
- You can then see your Turnitin similarity score, as well as further details about sources used, etc.
- When it is shown on the Turnitin page that the report has been generated, download the report in PDF format using the buttons on the right. Name it according to the assignment number, for example 'XJohn Smith Turnitin report'
- Upload that **report (not the receipt)** to the usual Scientific Writing ADAM Workspace into the folder 'Assignment XFinal draft'.

Assignment 2: Develop sentences into paragraphs

- Choose 3 topic sentences (see script lesson 2) and develop each of them into a paragraph of about 100-120 words. Use the techniques and linking words in the script and slides to improve cohesion and coherence. Reference all sources used in the text and in a short bibliography. Put your paragraph through the plagiarism check, Turnitin, on the special ADAM. Upload the Turnitin report too (not the receipt). (See instructions in the document 'Instructions for assignments.) choose your best short paragraph in your opinion and upload it to your column on the **Padlet** page of this course.
- Make a bullet point list of at least 5 points to focus on when reviewing your review partner's work.
- Name the assignment as follows: **2Surname name and upload the assignment onto ADAM.**
- Then, choose your best short paragraph in your opinion and upload it to the **Padlet** page of this course by the same due date.

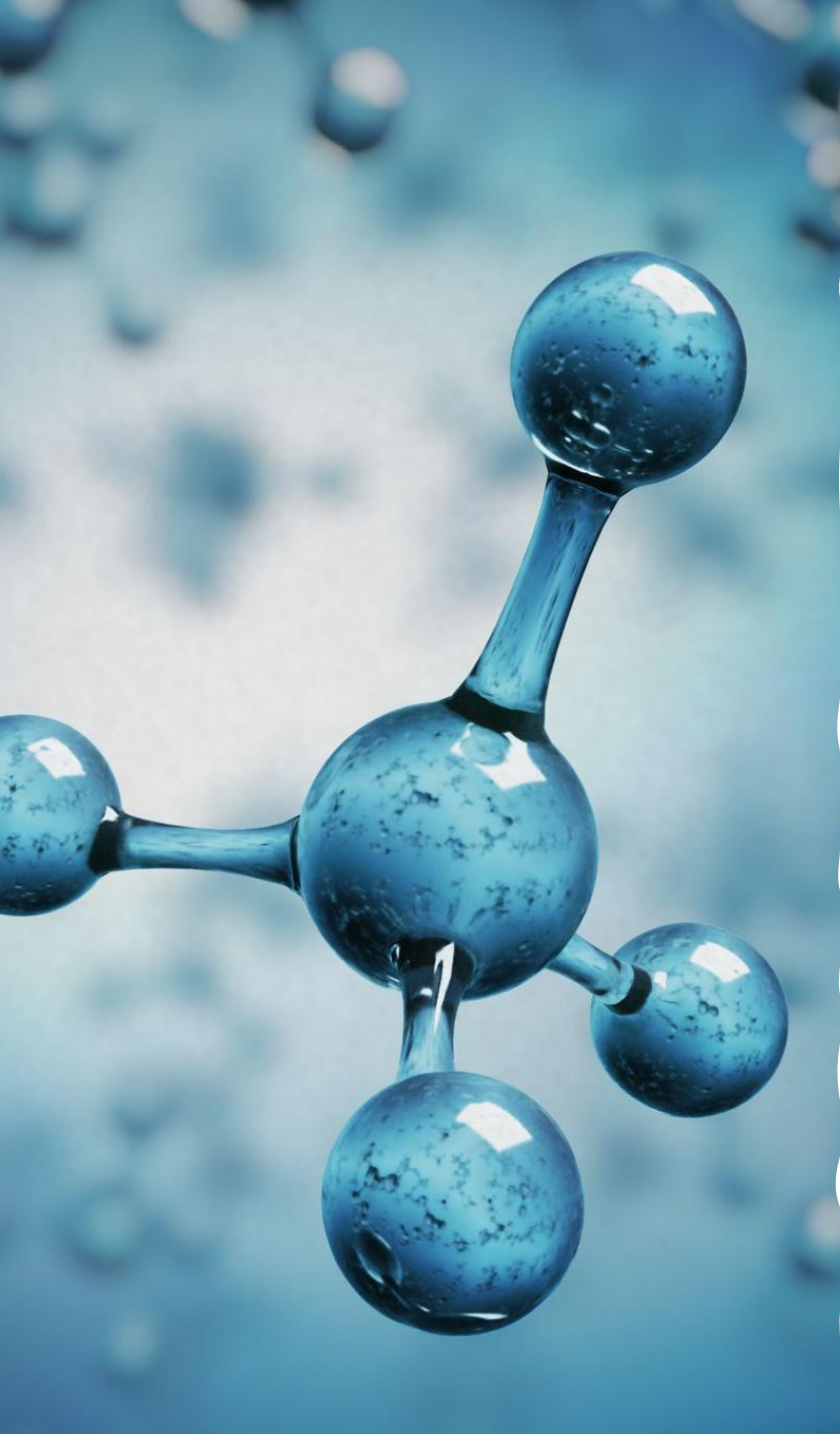




Reviewing assignments

Part focus of the course: how to review texts and each other's writing

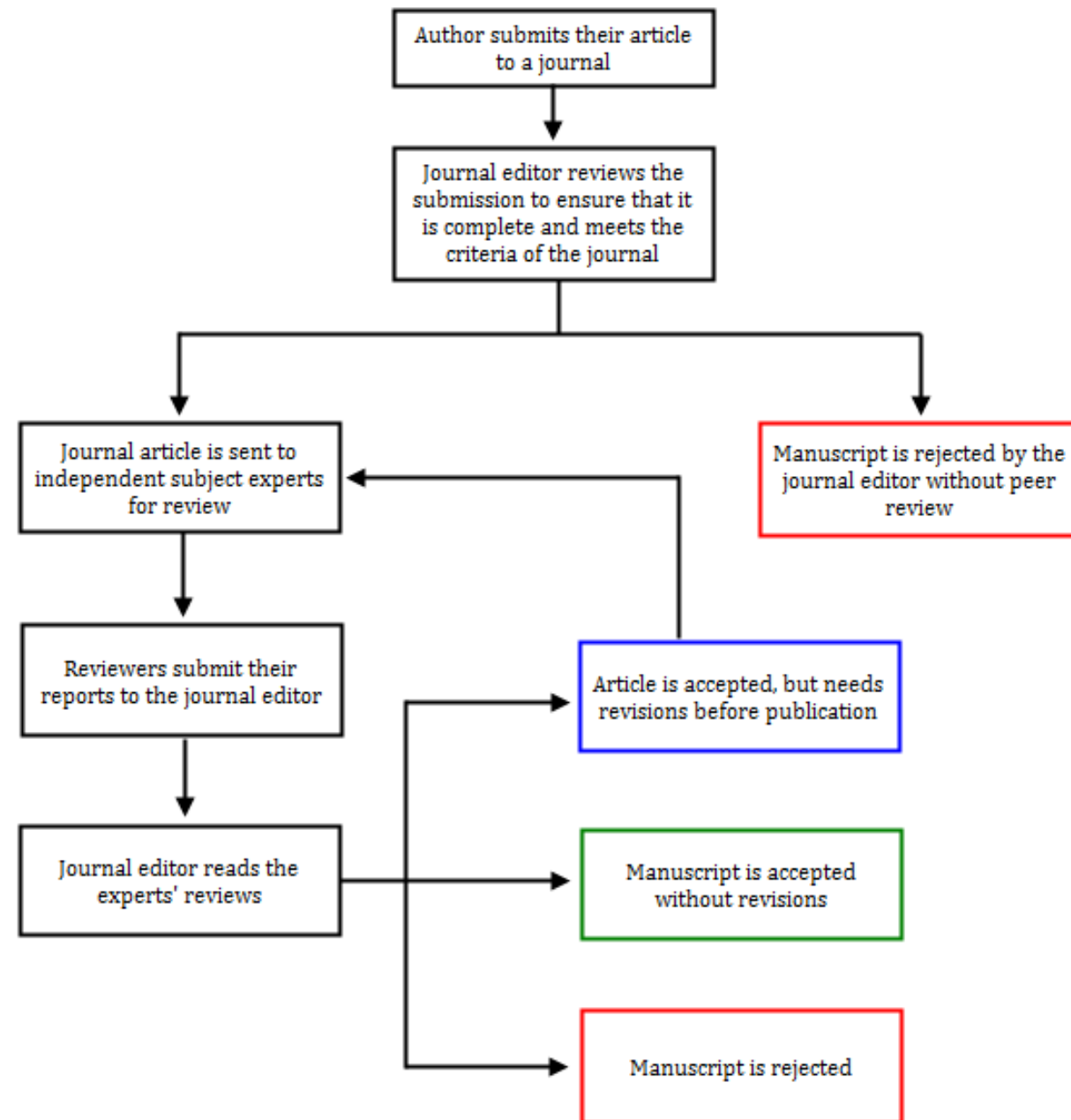
- Explanation of review process used in the class
- Explanation of the feedback grid used for reviewing
- Uploading all assignments on time **and reviewing** the 4 portfolio assignments form part of the course requirements.



Reviewing scientific publications

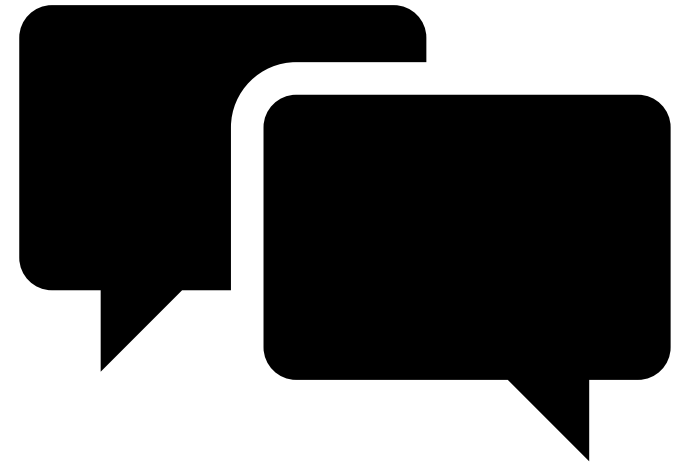
- Why?
- Who?
- How?

The peer review
processed followed
by journals



Discuss these questions

- In your opinion, what should be the **aims** and focus of your peer reviews of assignments?
- How could you **benefit** from writing and receiving peer reviews?
- How would you describe the **attitude** of the reviewer?



Benefits of peer feedback

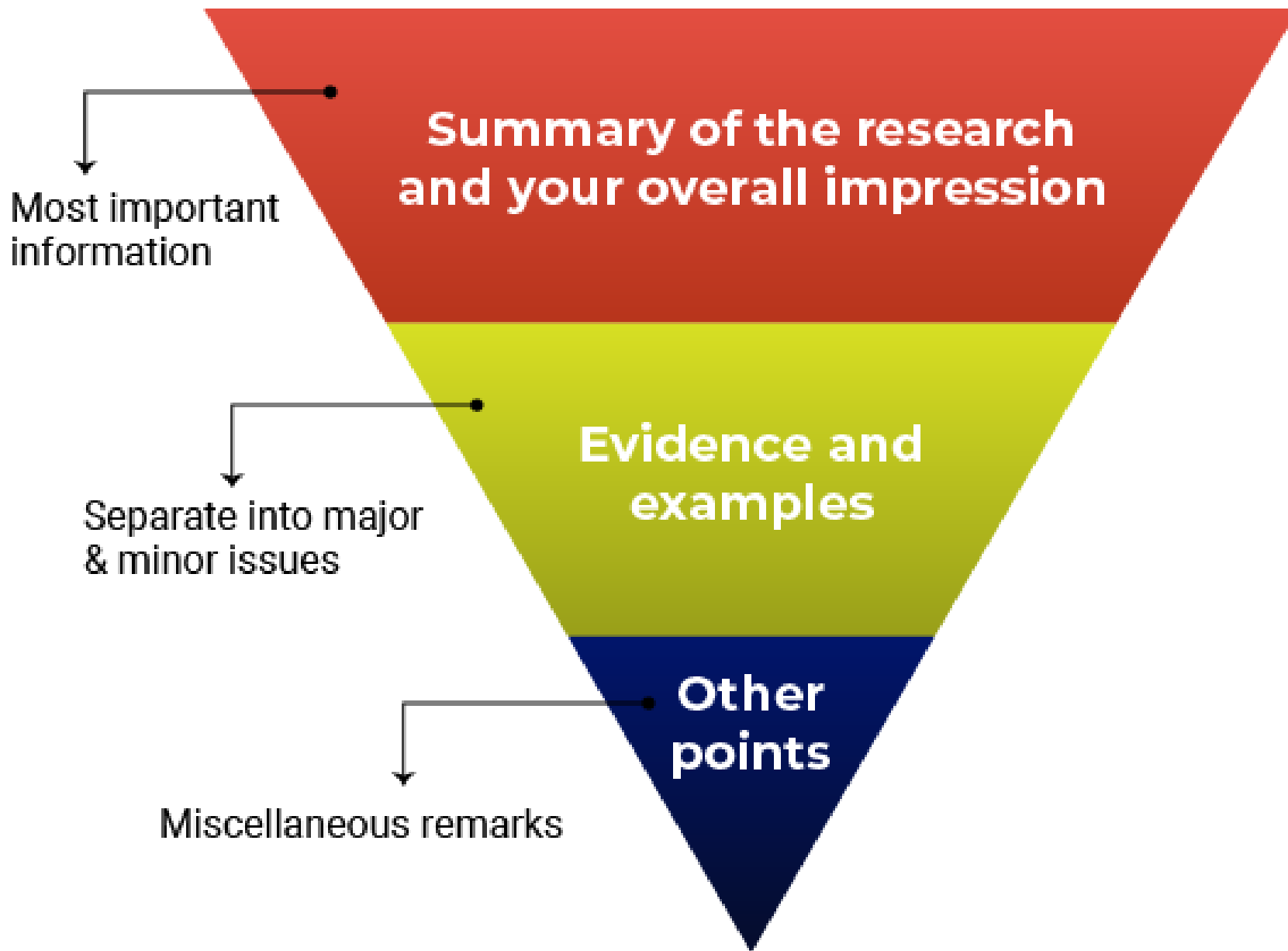
- Get to know your peers and learn about their study topics.
- Receive feedback from someone who might be less familiar with your topic, which helps to check the clarity of your text.
- Studies have confirmed the benefits of peer review in improving various aspects of writing: “...when students actively engage in the reciprocal process of peer review, their **concepts and knowledge about both writing and subject matter are further developed** (Jonassen et al., 1995), and **learning is enhanced** (Falchikov, 2001). Peer review is also beneficial for **developing students’ audience awareness, fostering social skills** such as learning how to **provide and accept critical comments, justifying one’s own position**, and declining nonproductive suggestions (Topping, 2009).“

Wu, Y.and Schunn, CD. American Educational Research Journal June 2021, Vol. 58, No. 3, pp. 492–526 DOI: 10.3102/0002831220945266
<https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1294485.pdf>

Why peer review?

Some benefits of giving peer feedback

	BENEFIT	CONSTRAINT
Cognitive	1. Exercise thinking 2. Take active role in learning 3. Engage in exploratory talk 4. Build critical skills 5. Demonstrate and reinforce knowledge 6. Build audience awareness	1. Uncertainty concerning peers' comments 2. Lack of learner investment
Social	1. Enhance communicative power 2. Receive authentic feedback 3. Gain confidence and reduce apprehension 4. Establish collegial ties and friendship 5. Influence learners' affective state	1. Discomfort and uneasiness 2. Lack of security in negotiating meaning 3. Commentary may be over critical
Linguistic	1. Enhance metalinguistic knowledge 2. Explore linguistic knowledge 3. Gain additional language skill practice 4. Enhance participation and improve discourse 5. Find right words to express ideas	1. Too much focus on surface structure 2. Lack of L2 formal schemata 3. Difficulty in understanding foreign accent
Practical	1. Applicable across students proficiency levels 2. Flexible across different stages in the writing process 3. Time-efficient in some cases 4. Reinforces process writing	1. Time constraints 2. Counter-productive feedback 3. Lack of student preparation



- [How to write a peer review](#) of a research paper

Higher Order

- Focus and Purpose
- Audience
- Organization and Document Design
- Development
- Readability

Lower Order

- Sentence Structure
- Punctuation
- Word Choice
- Spelling

Higher Order Concerns vs. Lower Order Concerns

How can I be a good peer reviewer?

- Watch the following video [on how to address Higher, Middle and Lower Order Concerns when peer reviewing](#)
- (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kMWZBDUIHUA>)

Higher Order Concerns (HOCs) vs. Lower Order Concerns (LOCs) when reviewing

(Adapted from <https://owl.excelsior.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/2/2019/04/How-to-Address-HOC-and-LOC.pdf>)

Higher Order Concerns address the “bigger picture” components of a written assignment. Always address the HOCs first!

- Main idea/Section focus and clarity
- Attention to audience and purpose
- Paragraphing
- Logical flow and organization
- Missing information/ideas/data
- Redundant/Extraneous information
- Enhancing development of ideas, thoughts, research narrative

Middle Order concerns mainly concern style

- Are sentences clear and easy to follow?
- Does the text flow – are ideas linked logically?
- Is the word choice engaging and appropriate?

When writing style prevents an author from communicating effectively, it becomes a HOC. If prose communicates ideas clearly, but lacks flair, style becomes a LOC.

Lower Order Concerns address mainly language use, minor changes and editing/proofreading

- Grammar, punctuation, spelling
- Word choice, vocabulary
- Sentence structure
- Referencing, citation accuracy

Such language problems do not normally make or break a text, but when they obscure an author’s ability to communicate effectively, they become HOCs.

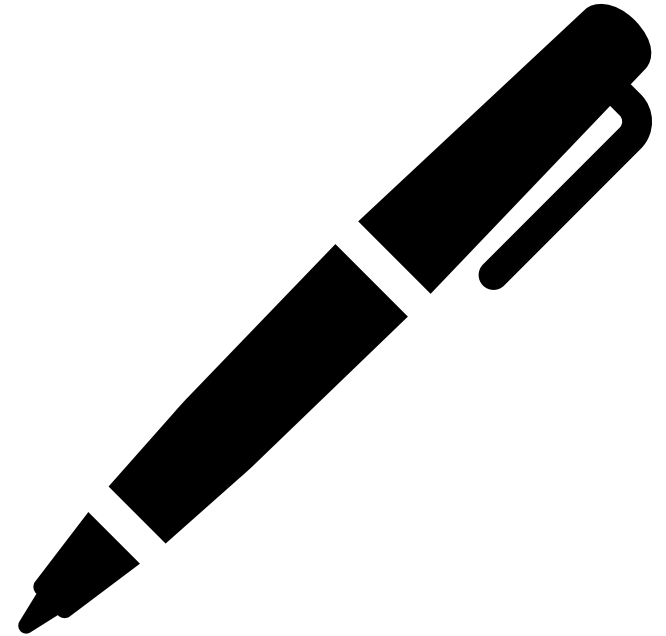
Peer review instructions

- Follow the review process and review schedule.
- Strictly adhere to due dates.
- Remain polite.
- Find something supportive to say.
- Write a developmental review: give constructive advice.
- Write a reviewer's summary paragraph.
- Point out Higher, Middle and Lower Order Concerns.

When you are on the receiving side of a peer review:

Try not to be too possessive of your writing, but be open to changes.

Reviewing can be tough: develop a thick skin!



Review: summary paragraph example 1

- The document '**Instructions for assignments**' on ADAM contains full instructions for the assignments, the peer review process in this course, including the peer review schedule (who reviews whose assignment), as well as the due dates for uploading the various drafts.
- During reviewing, students write a reviewer's summary paragraph of the reviewed assignment, as well as point out Higher, Middle and Lower Order Concerns in the writing.

Example of a reviewer's summary paragraph of an introduction section:

In this introduction, the author stresses the urgent need for preventive or therapeutic interventions against Ebola [= indicating a gap]. He/she then presents a novel compound that promises to block viral replication not only in Ebola, but in a range of related viruses [= filling the gap].

The author needs to revise the correct way of citing texts, as he/she cites inconsistently. Furthermore, there are several mistakes in the use of grammatical articles. But overall, the information flows well, in well-structured paragraphs.

Reviewer's summary example 2

At the end of the assignment, provide a reviewer's summary, a few sentences that address the paper as a whole, noting what works well and what needs improvement. For example:

Hi Percy—

I enjoyed reading your paper on the recent rise in popularity of organic foods. I think you have a strong thesis, and you support it with convincing evidence, especially in your paragraphs on Whole Foods and Trader Joe's. However, the paragraph on farmers' markets seems rather weak to me. I understand what you mean, but it reads more like opinion than fact. Are there any sources you could cite to make it sound more authoritative? I also wanted to mention that you often use the word "product," but I think you might mean "produce." Are those just typos? If you really mean "product," then you might want to define the term. I pointed out a few produce/product places for you above. Let me know if you have any questions about my comments.

Happy revising!

Annabeth

Developmental review

Provide **developmental reviews**: be specific about the problems in the manuscript and make suggestions as to how the problems might be addressed.

Provide written feedback so that the author can refer to it when s/he revises the paper. Be specific.

- POOR: “This is great!”
- BETTER: “Great—this example really supports what you said in the last paragraph. (Maybe it should go in the last paragraph instead of here?)”
- POOR: “This doesn’t make sense.”
- BETTER: “I don’t understand this—you said X above, but now you’re saying Y, which seems like the complete opposite. Do you really mean both?”

If you notice patterns of errors (for example, a word that is consistently misspelled, like produce/product above, or a punctuation mark that is consistently used incorrectly), then point out the pattern rather than marking all the errors.



How to review manuscripts

Peer review, your role and responsibilities

- How to review manuscripts.
- From the Elsevier website:
- <https://www.elsevier.com/connect/how-to-review-manuscripts-your-ultimate-checklist>

Peer review

...is critical because it

- Improves the quality of the published paper
- Ensures previous work is acknowledged
- Determines the importance of findings
- Detects plagiarism and fraud
- Plays a central role in academic career development

...adheres to the principles that

- It is a well understood concept
- Without it there is no control in scientific communication
- Journal editors evaluate and reject certain articles prior to external peer review

Why should you review?



Editors' view: what makes a good reviewer?

- Provides a thorough and comprehensive report
- Submits the report on time
- Provides well-founded comments for authors
- Gives constructive criticism
- Demonstrates objectivity
- Provides a clear recommendation to the editor

Comments to the editor

1 Comment on novelty and significance

2 Recommend whether the manuscript is suitable for publication

3 Confidential comments will not be disclosed to the author(s)

Your ultimate checklist for reviewing a paper

First impressions

- Is the research original, novel and important to the field?
- Has the appropriate structure and language been used?

Abstract

- Is it really a summary?
- Does it include key findings?
- Is it an appropriate length?

Introduction

- Is it effective, clear and well organized?
- Does it really introduce and put into perspective what follows?
- Suggest changes in organization and point authors to appropriate citations.
- Be specific – don't write "the authors have done a poor job"

Methodology

- Can a colleague reproduce the experiments and get the same outcomes?
- Did the authors include proper references to previously published methodology?
- Is the description of new methodology accurate?
- Could or should the authors have included supplementary material?

Results and discussion

- Suggest improvements in the way data is shown
- Comment on general logic and on justification of interpretations and conclusions
- Comment on the number of figures, tables and schemes
- Write concisely and precisely which changes you recommend
- List separately suggested changes in style, grammar and other small changes
- Suggest additional experiments or analyses
- Make clear the need for changes/updates
- Ask yourself whether the manuscript should be published at all

Conclusion

- Comment on importance, validity and generality of conclusions
- Request toning down of unjustified claims and generalizations
- Request removal of redundancies and summaries
- The abstract, not the conclusion, summarizes the study

References, tables and figures

- Check accuracy, number and citation appropriateness
- Comment on any footnotes
- Comment on figures, their quality and readability
- Assess completeness of legends, headers and axis labels
- Check presentation consistency
- Comment on need for colour in figures

Peer review questions to consider when reviewing a full article or proposal

- **Introduction.** Is the first paragraph an adequate statement of the manuscript's topic and approach? Did you know from the first paragraph where the paper was headed?
- **Continuity.** Is the line of argument (the 'golden thread') clear from paragraph to paragraph? Did each paragraph add to the argument?
- **Evidence.** Did the writer support the argument in a convincing manner?
- **Conclusion.** Does the conclusion draw together the strands of the argument? Is it a sufficient statement of the paper's main points?
- **Strengths.** What did you find best in the paper/text?
- What still requires improvement?

The assignment review process 1

Naming assignment example:
1Peter.Smith
first draft

- Follow the instructions on the document 'Instructions for assignments' on ADAM.
- That document contains the peer review schedule, so you can identify your reviewer for each assignment.
- By the due date, authors upload their WORD-format assignment for peer review to the folder entitled 'Assignment X First Draft' on ADAM, using the naming conventions explained on page 1. This first draft also requires upload to Turnitin if instructed. (Some assignments require upload to Padlet.)
- During Manuscript Clinics and in between classes, the reviewer reviews and corrects the assignment and makes comments (using 'Track changes'). Reviewers **also write a short review paragraph** (summary, main recommendations, HOCs and LOCs).
- Thereafter, the reviewer uploads the assignment (with comments) to the ADAM folder entitled 'REVIEWED DRAFT' by the due date, naming it **X surname name reviewed by YOUR NAME**.

The assignment review process 2

- Each writer downloads his/her reviewed assignment from ADAM and makes changes as applicable before uploading the final version to the 'FINAL DRAFT' folder, adding 'final' to the document name (for example **X Surname.Name final version**).
- The lecturer corrects and comments on the assignments before uploading them to the 'TUTOR'S' COMMENTS' folder, adding her initials to the document name. We recommend that you read this version of your assignment before class, so that you can ask any questions you may have.
- Be rigorous about adhering to due dates in order not to delay the reviewing and marking process. **Participating fully and timely in the peer review process is a requirement for receiving credits for the course.**